Two Sisters, One Vision

Brigade Enterprises' Pavitra and Nirupa Shankar are expanding the family business across real estate and hospitality

BY **KARAN DHAR**

A MOVE TO the US in 1999 to pursue higher studies was not meant to be the first step towards a career in real estate. Entering real estate, a largely male-dominated industry, initially seemed less likely.

But watching her father, M.R. Jaishankar, build Brigade Enterprises gradually changed Pavitra Shankar's perspective. The decision to return to Bengaluru, however, took longer to materialise.

"I met someone. He didn't want to leave the US. So, we ended up staying there for some time. I only came back to Bangalore in 2016. It's been about 10 years now, but yeah, I probably came here about eight years later than I wanted to. I sort of knew that once we moved back, it's like a forever move," she tells *Business Today*.

The real estate sector was not something that was really enticing at that point, says Pavitra, even though she "absolutely loves it" now.

Pavitra, who took over as managing director in October 2022, is carving out her own leadership identity rather than trying to emulate her father.

"I don't need to be him. I need to be me," she says, reflecting on how she has grown into the role. The second generation, she believes, has a different contribution to make from the founding generation.

Even though Pavitra leads Brigade Enterprises as Managing Director, there have been situations where people from outside see her and her sister as their father's daughters.

"I think there are situations in which people talk to us like we are his daughters and, it's a sweet thing, but sometimes they don't think of us as serious businesspeople. But it's not within the organisation. I see it a lot in external discussions. I don't pay too much attention to that," she says.

One of the things that has stood her in good stead is stepping up during difficult times.

Her sister, Nirupa Shankar, before taking on a leadership role in the real estate business as Joint Managing Director, also spent several years in the US. Fresh out of college, Nirupa joined EY as a risk advisory consultant.

A major hospitality buyout she worked on proved to be a turning point. The deal sparked her interest, prompting her to pursue a master's degree in hospitality at Cornell University. And in 2009, when Brigade was preparing to open its first hotel in India, Nirupa came back to India.

"I also had a choice to either join the residential side of the business and shadow my father or join the hotel business, which was a very small part of the business then (3% of the top line). I decided to choose hospitality," Nirupa tells *BT*.

One of the big highlights, Nirupa says, has been building the hospitality vertical at Brigade from scratch and taking it public after 17 years. "I felt it's always great when you can grow a company and see it from inception," she says.

Over the years, her portfolio has also expanded to office space and retail. "There was a turning point when one of our CEOs, who was managing office and retail, resigned after eight years. And at that point, my dad had said, 'Why don't you look at these two verticals as well?' " recalls Nirupa.

Nirupa looks after the entire annuity income business, which includes hospitality, office, and retail. "From next year onwards, facility management will also come under my portfolio," she says.

All the businesses with recurring income such as hotels, office, retail, and now facility management contribute 35-40% to the Brigade group's topline.

Pavitra's journey taught her that what isn't broken does not need fixing, and for her sister, unwinding entails participation in endurance sports and Iron Man triathlons. **BT**

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